



SPECTATOR SPORTS

This picture (left) shows the crowded grandstand (with a buffet in the foreground) during the Grande Semaine d'Aviation de la Champagne, held in Reims, August 22–29, 1909. Below, a Blériot XII is shown flying past a pylon during a race.



flight as a practical new technology. From August 22–29, on the desolate plain of Bétheny outside the city of Reims, in the Champagne region of eastern France, the world's leading aviators competed for lavish prizes mostly financed by the producers of the region's most famous product. A large investment of capital and the support of high-ranking individuals made this a prestige event. A railroad line was built to bring spectators from Reims. Stands, with accompanying bars and restaurants, were built to accommodate well-off spectators, while cheap tickets admitted the masses to the surrounding open ground. In all, almost 200,000 spectators

attended in the course of the week, including the president of France Armand Fallières, leading British politician David Lloyd George, former US president Teddy Roosevelt, and high-ranking military officers from around the world.

AN INDESCRIBABLE THRILL

THE REIMS MEETING OF AUGUST 1909 provided an extended aerial display of the machinery that was now conquering the skies. The full excitement of the Reims event was experienced by the few individuals who were taken up for a ride as passengers.

Gertrude Bacon, an Englishwoman with a reputation as an adventurous balloonist, went up in a Farman biplane and left a remarkable account of this uncomfortable and exhilarating experience. She first faced a scramble on to the lower plane of the wing, on which were mounted "the engine, its screw-propeller behind; and in front of it, right on the edge of the plane... the little basket seat of the pilot." Since "passenger flight had not been contemplated or arranged for", the only place for Bacon to sit was on the



ARTISTIC ADVERTISING

This colored lithograph poster by Ernest Montaut is an evocative advertisement for the world's first aviation meeting at Reims in 1909.

wing behind the pilot. When he scrambled in after her the pilot "was very close in front, wedging me tightly between himself and the extremely hot radiator." However, all discomfort was soon forgotten when "the mechanic swung the propeller, the engine... started with the first turn, and we

were off across the track. The ground was very rough and hard, and as we tore along... I expected to be jerked and jolted. But the motion was wonderfully smooth – and then – suddenly there [was] a new indescribable quality – a lift – a lightness – a life!"

French dominance

They saw 23 aviators fly in nine different types of aircraft, representing the entire world of aviation at that time – save for the marked absence of the Wright brothers. It was a sign of the predominance of the French in aviation that only two of the pilots were from abroad: Glenn Curtiss from the United States and Englishman George Cockburn. The French stars whom the public flocked to see included Louis Blériot, Hubert Latham, Henri Farman, and newcomer

Louis Paulhan, a mechanic who had recently won an aircraft in a newspaper competition and taught himself to fly.

The aircraft were of two general configurations. One group consisted of pusher biplanes with the elevator at the front and the propeller or propellers behind the pilot.

These included the Wright and Voisin biplanes and the Henri Farman III, which was to prove an immensely popular model over the following years. In the other main group were the tractor monoplanes, with the propeller at the

front and the elevator to the rear – mostly Blériots and Antoinettes. The one oddity was a tractor biplane designed by innovative Frenchman Louis Breguet. Although it did not perform well at Reims, this was the precursor to many future classic airplanes.

As long as weather conditions were reasonable, these contraptions of wire, wood, and fabric were all viable flying machines. They were capable of flying at around 40mph (65kph) for an hour or more, and were satisfactorily controllable in simple maneuvers, performing turns and circuits. Some used Wright-style wing warping for their control in roll, while others employed some

